other men.[31] Child marriages were common among the Brahmins and certain upper castes. Add to this the custom of sati and what we have here is a very oppressive place for royal and aristocratic women even by medieval Indian standards.[32]

Yet another Persianate import in south India, it seems to me, was a markedly higher level of military violence. The fighting ferocity of Turko-Afghan horsemen of the Delhi Sultanate—born of a culture of greater military discipline, meritocracy, and battlefield innovations— meant that any ruling class of Hindus who could challenge them would also have to be equally violent, with a similarly keen instinct in pursuing and protecting its own interests. Such indeed was the ruling class at Vijayanagar.

The Fall of Vijayanagar

A great war took place in 1565 at Talikota between Vijayanagar and four Deccan Sultanates. A key personality here was Rama Raya (1484–1565), son of a prominent general of Vijayanagar. Curiously, earlier in his life, in 1512, Rama Raya had enlisted for three years 'in the service of the sultan of Golkonda', a great rival of Vijayanagar. This illustrates the high degree of mobility that elite warriors enjoyed, beyond religious considerations. Back in Vijayanagar, Rama Raya later married Krishnadevaraya's daughter, and, as regent, rose to become its de facto ruler in 1543. For the next two decades, he played a great game with the sultans, allying with some, playing one off against another. According to Stein, 'A combination of high skill and arrogance characterised [his] policies toward the Muslim sultanates of the Deccan.' K.A. Nilakanta Sastri, acclaimed historian of south India, writes, 'Rama Raya paid heavily for his miscalculations. His policy opened the direct road to the disaster of [Talikota].'[33]

One such miscalculation may have followed a war in 1558–59 in which Rama Raya had allied with Bijapur to defeat Ahmadnagar and Golconda. According to Firishta, Vijayanagar's victorious army 'left no cruelty unpractised. They insulted the honor of the mussulmaun women, destroyed the mosques, and did not even respect the sacred koraun'.[34] It's unclear if Firishta is embellishing or reporting only part of the story, but Sastri,